RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Gan Eden & Gehinom: What, Where and When?

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 4

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, continued: Gan Eden and Gehinom in depth

Shiur: Part 4 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 21 October 2025 (Rosh Chodesh Cheshvan, after the festivals; the week of Bereishit)

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

- **Five views** of the ultimate reward and punishment: **Gan Eden/Gehinom**, **Mashiach's days**, **resurrection**, **this world**, **all combined**. **All physical. The real thing is Olam HaBa.**
- **The parable:** sweets, then money, then clothes, then fame, until we learn **because learning is right**. **The ideal is service without ulterior motive.**
- **Three readings of aggadah:**
- **literal**: "sad, wrong, foolish";
- **"the Sages didn't understand"**: "**very angry**";
- **deep messages masked in simple words for the masses**: the Rambam's own.
- **Olam HaBa**: **עין לא ראתה**: indescribable, as sight is to the blind or heat to a fish. "**He himself doesn't fully understand it.**" Its essence: **נהנים מזיו השכינה**, **relationship with Hashem**.
- **Don't serve *for* Olam HaBa**, though it **is** the ultimate. ("I don't like the words *reward and punishment*; for simplicity, we'll use them.")
- **This-worldly blessings and curses** (Ki Tavo, Bechukotai, Shema) are **consequences, not rewards**: **בדרך שאדם רוצה לילך מוליכין אותו; המקיים את התורה מעוני סופו לקיימה מעושר**. Hashem **removes distractions**, or allows them.

Tonight: Gan Eden and Gehinom again, "because I picked up some new points over the weeks without shiurim, and tried as much as possible to make order of this."

Part 1: Gan Eden

וגן עדן הוא מקום דשן ושמן מבחר הארץ... יגלה אותו השם לבני אדם לעתיד לבוא, ויורה אותם הדרך ללכת אליו.

"Think of **a beautiful oasis**." Streams and trees, perhaps **wondrous** plants and medicines beyond ours: "**really utopia**." Hashem must **show the way**, since, as we read **last Shabbat in Bereishit**, He **banished Adam and Chavah** and guarded the entrance.

ונהר יצא מעדן להשקות את הגן ומשם יפרד והיה לארבעה ראשים.

Three views of Gan Eden

Rav Shilat points to **Berachot 28b**: **Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai**, dying, wept:

יש לפני שני דרכים, אחת של גן עדן ואחת של גיהנם, ואיני יודע באיזו מוליכים אותי, ולא אבכה?

	Rav Saadia Gaon (Monday night, "it just worked out")	The Ramban	The Rambam
Gan Eden is...	**Synonymous with Olam HaBa**	A **spiritual** place: a **waiting room** for souls until resurrection, when **body and soul** are reunited in a **new world** after the 6,000 years	A **physical place on earth**, separate from Olam HaBa
Physical?	**Yes**, since his Olam HaBa is physical	**No**	**Yes**
Accepted?	"**No one really took it on**"		

The mainstream (Rambam and Ramban): **Gan Eden and Gehinom are distinct from Olam HaBa**, but **the Sages use them as shorthand for it**, since they're what people can relate to. **Gan Eden** is in the Torah; **Gehinom** is from **גיא בן הנם**, the valley where people were **burned** as sacrifices. So Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai's "two paths" means **Olam HaBa** or **karet**.

Then why does the Rambam insist on a physical Gan Eden?

Because **the Torah describes one**: a garden, rivers, plants. "**It's wrong to claim the Rambam held all of Bereishit to be one big metaphor.**" (The **snake** is debated.) So he wouldn't strip away the simple meaning entirely.

Where is it, and has it been found?

"**Looking at it again**, I don't think the Rambam necessarily says it's **here now**." **יגלה** may mean Hashem will **bring it back**. Perhaps when humanity was banished, **the place itself was withdrawn** from the earth, to be **re-exposed** when its time comes. **One opinion in Eruvin**: only **the entrance** to Gan Eden is on earth. "**Both readings are possible.**"

When?

The Ramban (*Sha'ar HaGemul*): during **Mashiach's days or the resurrection**, "the most logical way to understand it," and for the Rambam the two **come together** to some extent. **Not now, and not Olam HaBa**, which is **souls and Hashem alone**, with **no earth left**.

Why have it at all?

"The only explanation I have: **everything must revert to its original state** before this physical universe ends."

> Once you notice it you can't forget it: **Bereishit almost never says *Adam***," **האדם, not אדם.** always ***ha'adam***, **humankind**." Not that there was no person called Adam: "**the one time** it

says *Adam* is when he **dies**." But **humanity** was banished from Eden, so **humanity must return**.

Part 2: Gehinom

ואמנם גיהנם הוא שם לצער ולעונש שישיג לרשעים, ולא פירשו בתלמוד תואר זה העונש.

Some say	Proof
The sun draws near and burns them	exactly the verse Rav Saadia quoted ("**הנה היום בא בער כתנור**" ("last night")
A strange heat arises inside their bodies, a fever	**רוחכם אש תאכלכם**

Full stop. The Sages use Gehinom as **shorthand for karet**, yet **for the Rambam there's still something physical**: **heat**, fittingly for a name from **the valley of fire**.

"They are judged according to their sins"

The **Mishneh Torah** (Hilchot Teshuvah):

וכן כל הרשעים שעונותיהן מרובים, דנין אותן כפי חטאיהם, ויש להן חלק לעולם הבא.

A **complete** *rasha* has **no portion**: **karet**. But this is a sinner who **does** have a portion. **What does "judged according to their sins" mean?**

Reading	
1. Their place	*(Class: "the stadium analogy.")* **A seat further back**: a less intense bliss. "**That was always my understanding, and I believe the main one.**"
2. Gehinom	Sins must be **purged**, and punishment purges. It fits **twelve months**: a karet-bound *rasha* needs no Gehinom, he's simply cut off

"Aren't we reading the colloquial Gehinom into the text?" "**I hear that**, which is why I think the first reading is simpler. **But then what's Gehinom *for*?** The complete *rasha* is cut off; the partial one sits further back. **Why burn him?** I'm asking myself. **I don't know.**"

Daniel: the wicked rise too

ורבים מישני אדמת עפר יקיצו, אלה לחיי עולם ואלה לחרפות לדראון עולם (Daniel 12:2)

The Rambam's *Letter on Resurrection* calls this **the clearest source** for resurrection. **"Some to everlasting life, some to shame."** So, answering **Maurice's question** from last time, **the wicked will be resurrected** too, which suggests (the Rabbi's "own conjecture") that **Gan Eden and Gehinom begin at the resurrection**, on earth.

Two kinds of *resha'im*:

	Fate
The ultimate *rasha*, אין להם חלק (very few)	**Karet**: they die, the soul is cut off. **They don't rise**
sinners **who are still Israel**, with a **חוטאי ישראל**: portion	**They rise, and are purged in Gehinom**, then continue

The Ramban's reading

Even those with karet pass through Gehinom, because otherwise how do you distinguish one who ate **chametz on Pesach** or **on Yom Kippur** *once* from one who did it **for 120 years**? ("*Chametz on Yom Kippur* is karet too!") **So Gehinom's intensity matches the count.**

The Rabbi: "I find that difficult. The Rambam would answer: even the cut-off have **some consciousness** that they're cut off. **A hundred karets = a deeper awareness of what's lost.**"

A class objection: *why need levels? We don't execute someone ten times for ten murders. Death is the ultimate.* "**I don't agree with the proof**: every court execution comes with **karet** as well. **But the idea, that karet is simply the ultimate, I hear very strongly.**"

"It feels like a lot is intentionally left out." "**Correct.** People like to know exactly. **But these aren't the *ikkarim*.**"

Not principles of faith

Gan Eden and Gehinom are not *ikkarei emunah*. Contrast what comes next: **techiyat hametim** is **יסוד מיסודות משה רבנו**, deny it and you have **no portion**; **Mashiach**, likewise. **Gan Eden** appears in the Mishneh Torah only in the **Sheva Berachot** (**כשמחך יצירך בגן עדן מקדם**); **Gehinom** only once. "**Whatever they are, don't spend too long on them.** In the grand scheme, they're very minor."

Questions

Q: In the Rambam's view, what happens to a sinner with a portion between death and resurrection?

"**He begins his Olam HaBa**, maybe further back, but **with an impediment**: he can't fully experience it until the **purging**, which comes at the resurrection." *Why make him wait?* "**I don't know.**"

ילכו מחיל אל חיל (Tehillim 84, said at Minchah): the Gemara: **צדיקים אין להם מנוחה לא בעולם הזה ולא בעולם הבא**: **there's growth in Olam HaBa**.

The *Hashkavah*. "That's why I've never liked the Spanish and Portuguese *Hashkavah*: **מנוחה נכונה בישיבה עליונה**, *true rest in the academy on high*. **What rest? The righteous have no rest!**" The **Arizal** used a simpler text (**טוב שם משמן טוב... שם תהא מנוחתו**), though for a different reason: he disliked the **hyperbolic** terms.

Q: Doesn't Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai's "two paths" fit the Ramban well, Gan Eden and Gehinom right after death?

"Only on **Rav Saadia's** view. Otherwise it's **proof** the Sages used Gan Eden and Gehinom as **shorthand for Olam HaBa**: what else can you tell people about the ultimate punishment? /

know the story of Gan Eden; I know the fires."

Richard: those with karet, do they enter Gehinom?

"**I have a proof: they do not.** They don't rise for Gehinom. **Only those with a portion do.**"

> People **love** quoting it. **That's half the Mishnah.** In the" **"כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא"**
> ".and a whole list ,**ואלו שאין להם חלק**: prayer book it stops there; the source continues

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The Timeline

	The Rambam	Rav Saadia	The Ramban
At death	**The complete *rasha*: karet**. Everyone else **begins Olam HaBa**, by their spiritual level	(Unexplained)	**A spiritual waiting room**: Gan Eden or Gehinom
In the future, on earth	**Mashiach and resurrection** (order unstated). The **righteous rise** and enjoy **Gan Eden**; **sinners with a portion rise** and pass through **Gehinom**'s physical heat. **The cut-off stay cut off**	**A new world** = Olam HaBa = Gan Eden/Gehinom, **body and soul**, with **heat or light**	**Resurrection** of body and soul into **Olam HaBa**, **ending** Gan Eden and Gehinom
Finally	That period ends, **the world ends**, and **only souls exist eternally with Hashem**		

Summary

1. **Gan Eden**: **three views**: Rav Saadia (= Olam HaBa), the Ramban (spiritual waiting room), the Rambam (**a physical place on earth**, revealed or **returned** in the future, during **Mashiach/resurrection**, because **humanity, *ha'adam*, must return to Eden**).
2. The Sages use Gan Eden and Gehinom as **shorthand** for Olam HaBa and karet, **but the Rambam won't strip away the Torah's physical Eden.**
3. **Gehinom**: **burning**, from the sun or within. "**Judged according to their sins**": a **further seat**, or **Gehinom's purging**.
4. **Daniel 12:2**: the **wicked rise** too: **sinners with a portion** for Gehinom; **the cut-off never rise**. (The Ramban: Gehinom for karet too, by count; the Rabbi prefers **degrees of awareness**.)
5. **Neither is a principle of faith.** Resurrection and Mashiach **are**.

Coming Up

Next week: techiyat hametim and Mashiach, then **a complete overview of everything**.

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